

NEW WORLD CONQUEST

AZTECS AND CONQUISTADORS

From 1519, the Aztec Empire faced an invasion by Spanish conquistadors – men from an alien military tradition with superior technology. The struggle for control of the capital, Tenochtitlán, revealed the Aztec army's dependence on stone weaponry and their ritualistic attitude to warfare.

The Aztec Emperor Moctezuma II at first welcomed the Spanish and their Indian allies, the Tlaxcaltec, into his palace in Tenochtitlán, but relations soon soured. The Spanish took Moctezuma hostage, and the Aztec population became increasingly hostile. In June 1520, fighting broke out. Moctezuma was killed – whether by the Spanish, or his own people, is not known – and the Spanish were besieged in the royal palace. On the night of 30 June, they attempted to escape along the causeways that linked the city, built on an island in Lake Texcoco, to the shore. Aztec warriors in war canoes attacked the Spanish, shooting arrows and climbing onto the causeways to strike them with clubs. Of about 1,000 conquistadors, probably two-thirds were killed, taken prisoner, or wounded.

THE SHOCK OF THE NEW

Under a new emperor, Cuitláhuac, the Aztecs sought to complete their victory by pursuing the remnants of the Spanish force. An Aztec army set out, splendidly arrayed, the officers wearing elaborate feathered displays on bamboo frames and marching under colourful standards. They caught up with the Spanish at the plain of Otumba. The Aztecs greatly outnumbered their enemy, probably by at least twenty to one. Their noble warriors, hardened to warfare from an early age, were physically fearless fighters. They had no metal weapons, but their wooden clubs and spears were edged with razor-sharp black obsidian blades. As well as bows and arrows they had javelins that could be launched to considerable distance using a throwing stick, or *atlatl*. The

primary objective of a warrior was not to kill his opponents but to maim them and capture them alive. Nonetheless, after battle was joined the Spanish suffered steady attrition. The tide was turned not by the conquistadors' few gunpowder weapons or their steel swords, but by their horses – animals unknown to the Aztecs before the Europeans' arrival. The Spanish commander Hernán Cortés led a small cavalry charge into the Aztec ranks and ran down their commanders. The psychological impact of this bold and unexpected action routed the Aztecs, who soon abandoned the field in disarray.

THE TAKING OF TENOCHTITLÁN

The following year, reinforced with large numbers of Tlaxcaltec and other native allies, Cortés placed Tenochtitlán under siege. In the defence of the city the Aztecs proved far more resolute than in open field. They fought fiercely to hold the causeways giving access to the city across the lake, until these were made untenable by the fire of small cannon mounted in Spanish boats. Then they defended their city street by street. Confronting crossbows, arquebuses, and steel swords with their weapons of wood and stone, they repeatedly repelled incursions by the Spanish and their allies, throwing missiles from the rooftops and ambushing isolated groups of soldiers. The Aztecs remained undefeated through 10 weeks of siege, but eventually the Spanish blockade of the city led to a shortage of food, forcing them to surrender. In August 1521, the Aztec civilization came to an end.

